> If he starboarded at once he was certain to run down one or the other [boats]. If he ported, which would be very unnautical, he could blanket the boat and going in the same direction would finally run her down, or if he ported continuously would have finally ended in striking *Nadia*. He took the only course, tried to get between the boats and failed. Time was too short to get away from the steamer even though he did reverse engines. We cannot expect him to know that boats would be in his course as they were astern when he heaved anchorage and were cast off when he went around the bows of *Pandua*.

The court of inquiry concluded that, 'No one can be blamed; pure bad luck.' And that the '… accident was unavoidable, captain of *Lawoe* did everything that seamanship demanded from the moment he was able to see boats to attempt to avoid disaster.'

The *Lawoe* was involved in another mishap a week later, but this time in Colombo. On 1 August it collided with, and caused a slight damage to the *Bloemfontein*, a British screw steamer sailing from Calcutta to New York, lying in anchor. Though no life or cargo was lost, even according to an official report,[145] the owners of the *Bloemfontein* took the *Lawoe* to court and got it impounded. It could sail to Tuticorin only after its underwriters bailed it out. *The Hindu* reassured its readers that SSNCo was fully insured and there was no cause for anxiety.[146] But the matter did not end there. Messrs Julies and Cressy, on behalf of the *Bloemfontein*, claimed Rs 50,000 in damages. A writ of arrest was issued and the court martial, accompanied by his peons, served the summons and affixed the writ. The attorney of SSNCo appeared before the registrar of the Supreme Court of Ceylon and offered security; but the money was not paid as they discovered, somewhat late in the day, that the ship was insured against all risks. Here a curious situation obtained: Messrs Aitkin Spence and Company, *Bloemfontein*'s agent turned out to be the underwriters' agent as well. As *The Hindu* observed wryly, they would have 'to fight for the *Bloemfontein* and at the same time defend the *Lawoe*'. The last we hear is that one Mr Boake came to ascertain the damages. Nothing is heard of this collision subsequently and possibly, given the quandary of the insurer, the matter was resolved smoothly.[147]